

Sri Lanka Tour Booking Platform — Product Plan

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1. Vision & goals

Working name: **Sri Lanka Navigator**. The platform helps international tourists plan a Sri Lanka trip end-to-end in one place, then either hand the plan to a vetted local tour guide or company through a competitive bidding marketplace, or execute it themselves by booking vehicles, trains, and buses directly.

Three-sided value: travelers get one tool to research, budget, and plan a trip, then receive competing offers from verified local experts instead of hunting across scattered agencies and review sites. Guides and companies get a steady stream of qualified, ready-to-quote trip requests instead of relying on walk-ins, referrals, or ad spend. The platform earns a commission by owning the trust layer (verification plus ratings) that neither side can easily replicate alone.

Launch focus is international tourists first, so early priorities are strong English content, multi-currency price display, clear trust signals for first-time visitors (verification badges, review counts, response times), and payment methods that work for foreign cards (Stripe/PayPal-style, not just local bank transfer).

2. User types & roles

- **Traveler** — browses locations, plans a trip (map, budget, transport), optionally posts it for bids, books guides/companies or self-service transport, rates providers after the trip.
- **Tour guide** (individual, freelance) — registers with ID, licenses (Sri Lanka Tourism Development Authority guide license where applicable), languages spoken, specialties, and areas covered; bids on posted trips; manages a calendar; gets rated.
- **Tour company** — registers as a business (business registration doc, insurance, fleet details); can list multiple staff guides and vehicles under one account; bids on trips, especially larger or multi-day/group ones.

- **Vehicle/transport operator** (optional separate role) — car/van/tuk-tuk rental operators and private drivers who only offer self-drive or chauffeured transport, not full guiding.
- **Platform admin** — verifies guide/company registrations, moderates disputes and reviews, manages payouts and commission, handles support tickets, oversees content (location pages, timetables).

A single person could hold both a Traveler and a Guide account, but the two roles should stay on separate profiles/dashboards to keep trust signals clean (e.g., a guide shouldn't be able to rate themselves as a traveler).

3. Core trip-planning features

Interactive map. All locations (beaches, temples, national parks, waterfalls, hill country towns, etc.) plotted on a map with clustering by region; filter by category, distance from current itinerary stops, or opening hours; draw the traveler's planned route between stops with estimated drive time.

Location information pages. Per-location: description, best time to visit, entry fees, opening hours, photos, accessibility notes, safety notes, nearby amenities (ATMs, hospitals, restrooms), and average time needed. Sourced initially from curated content, later enriched by traveler reviews and guide contributions.

Location suggestions. A recommendation engine that suggests stops based on trip length, interests selected at onboarding (wildlife, culture, beaches, adventure, food, wellness), season/weather, and route efficiency — e.g., "you're already near Ella, add Nine Arch Bridge and Little Adam's Peak."

Budget planner. Line-item estimate covering accommodation tier, transport mode, entry fees, food, guide/company fees (once selected), and a contingency buffer; shown in the traveler's home currency with live or daily FX rates; adjustable sliders per category so travelers can see trade-offs (e.g., downgrade transport to afford a guide).

Transportation options. Overview of available modes per route segment — private car with driver, self-drive rental, tuk-tuk, public bus, and train — with rough cost and duration for each, feeding both the budget planner and the booking flow in section 6.

Save & revisit trips. A traveler doesn't have to post or book right away — any itinerary being built can be saved to their account as a draft and returned to later from a "My Trips" dashboard. Saved trips are viewable on the interactive map as a plotted route (stops in order, with drive-time between them), the same view used during planning, so travelers

can visually review a saved plan before deciding to post it for bids or check out a self-planned booking. Travelers can also duplicate a saved trip as the starting point for a new one, and rename/archive old drafts.

4. Guide & company marketplace

Registration & verification. Guides and companies sign up with identity/business documents, licenses, insurance (for companies), languages, service areas, and sample work/photos. Every new account starts in a "pending verification" state and is invisible to travelers until an admin approves it — checking document authenticity, license validity, and (ideally) a phone/video call. Verified accounts get a visible badge; rejected ones get a reason and can resubmit.

Profiles. Public profile per guide/company: bio, languages, specialties, years active, verification badge, rating and review count, sample itineraries, response time, and price range. Companies can show their team of guides and fleet.

Trip posting & bidding. Once a traveler finishes planning, they can post the trip (dates, locations, group size, budget range, preferences) to the marketplace. Matching verified guides/companies get notified and submit bids: price, what's included (transport, meals, entry fees), a short pitch, and availability confirmation. Bidding runs on a deadline (e.g., 48–72 hours) so travelers get quotes without an endless open-ended auction.

Selection. Traveler compares bids side by side (price, rating, response time, what's included) and messages shortlisted bidders before committing. On acceptance, a booking is created, payment is escrowed, and losing bidders are notified automatically.

In-app messaging between traveler and bidders (pre- and post-booking) keeps everything on-platform, which matters both for trust/moderation and for making sure the commission can't easily be bypassed by taking the deal off-platform.

5. Rating & trust system

Both sides rate each other after a completed trip, on a delay (e.g., 3 days post-trip) so it's based on the real experience, not the sales pitch. Ratings are mutual-blind until both submit or a deadline passes, which discourages retaliatory or extorted reviews.

Travelers rate guides/companies on: punctuality, knowledge/communication, value for money, safety, and would-recommend, plus a free-text review and optional photos. Guides/companies rate travelers on: clarity of requirements, respectfulness, and

payment reliability — kept lower-profile (e.g., a private reputation score visible to other guides/companies, not a public traveler profile) since public traveler-shaming isn't the goal.

Trust signals beyond the star rating: verification badge, response-time average, completion rate (bids won vs. trips actually delivered), years on platform, and a dispute history flag visible only to admins. Fake/incentivized reviews are discouraged by only allowing reviews tied to a completed, paid booking (no reviews without a transaction).

6. Self-planned trips (no guide/company)

Since this was scoped as full in-app booking, travelers can build and pay for a trip entirely without a guide:

- **Vehicle rental** — self-drive cars or chauffeured cars/vans/tuk-tuks from partnered rental operators, with real-time availability calendars, pricing by duration and vehicle class, and in-app payment/deposit.
- **Train booking** — integration with Sri Lanka Railways schedules and, where an official booking API/partnership exists, seat reservation and ticketing (especially popular scenic routes like Kandy–Ella); where no API exists, show accurate timetables and fares with a clear note on where the physical/official ticket is issued.
- **Bus booking** — intercity/express bus timetables and, for private/luxury bus operators, in-app seat booking; regular SLTB routes may only support timetable display if no booking API exists.
- **Combined itinerary checkout** — a traveler can mix modes (train Colombo→Kandy, rental car Kandy→Ella, bus Ella→Galle) and pay for the whole self-planned trip in one checkout, with each leg's confirmation/ticket delivered separately.

This path shares the same map, location, and budget tools as the guided path — the fork is only at "do you want a guide bidding on this, or are you booking it yourself." Note as an open item: real-time train/bus data depends on whether Sri Lanka Railways/private operators expose an API or require a scraping/partnership approach (flagged again in section 12).

7. Monetization

- **Commission on bids/bookings (primary).** A percentage taken from the guide/company payout when a bid is won and the trip completes (e.g., 10–15%, tunable by category); also a smaller cut on self-planned vehicle/train/bus bookings made

through the platform.

- **Featured listings / promoted bids.** Guides/companies can pay to appear higher in search results or have their bid highlighted (clearly labeled as promoted, never hiding the rating), or to get more monthly trip-request notifications.
- **Free for guides/companies at launch.** No listing or subscription fee to join and bid while supply is being built — monetize only on successful transactions and optional promotion, which lowers the barrier for guides to sign up early. Revisit a subscription tier later once there's enough deal flow to justify it.

Payment flow: traveler pays into escrow on booking acceptance; funds release to the guide/company (minus commission) on a defined state machine — booking confirmed → trip start → trip end + a fixed hold window (e.g., 24–48 hours) → auto-release unless a dispute is opened — which also gives the platform leverage to enforce the rating/dispute process.

Note on self-planned bookings: the commission there only works where the platform actually processes the payment (e.g., a partnered vehicle-rental operator's checkout). For train and bus legs where no booking API exists (flagged in section 6 and section 12), the platform can't take a cut of a ticket it never sold — those legs stay informational (timetable/fare display) until a real payment integration exists.

8. Additional feature suggestions

Trust & safety

- SOS / emergency button in the traveler app with location sharing and local emergency numbers.
- Live trip tracking so a traveler's chosen contact can follow their route in real time.
- Verified-only toggle and "new provider" labeling so travelers know when a bidder has few reviews yet.
- Dispute resolution flow with admin mediation and partial-refund rules baked into the escrow logic.

Content & discovery

- Curated themed itineraries ("7-day cultural triangle," "honeymoon south coast") travelers can start from and customize instead of planning from a blank map.
- Weather and seasonal overlays on the map (monsoon patterns differ between the west/south and east coasts — genuinely useful for Sri Lanka specifically).

- Local events/festival calendar (Kandy Esala Perahera, Sinhala/Tamil New Year, etc.) that can shift itinerary suggestions.
- Multi-language support (at minimum English, with Sinhala/Tamil for local guides and German/French/Chinese/Russian for common visitor segments).

Marketplace depth

- Package add-ons guides/companies can offer: airport pickup, SIM card/eSIM assistance, cooking classes, photography add-ons.
- Group/split-cost trips where multiple unrelated travelers can join one bid to share a guide and vehicle cost.
- Guide specialization tags (birding, surfing, Ayurveda/wellness, diving, hiking) so bids match traveler interests, not just location.
- Instant-book option for simple, standard-priced services (e.g., a fixed-route airport-to-hotel transfer) that skips the bidding wait for travelers who just want it booked now.

Operations & growth

- Referral program for both travelers (discount) and guides (waived commission on first booking).
- Post-trip automated review request + "share your trip" social content generator to drive organic marketing.
- Offline mode / downloadable itinerary and maps for areas with poor connectivity, common outside Colombo.
- Travel insurance upsell partnership at checkout.
- Analytics dashboard for guides/companies (win rate, average bid price, repeat customers) to help them price competitively.

Open question worth flagging back to you: do you want the platform to also support hotel/accommodation booking, or is that intentionally left out (with travelers booking lodging elsewhere)? It's a natural extension but a much bigger scope (its own supply/inventory problem), so it's called out separately rather than assumed.

9. Suggested tech stack & architecture

This is a two-sided marketplace with maps, payments, and messaging — solid, boring, well-supported technology matters more than novelty here.

- **Frontend:** React or Next.js (web app, responsive for mobile browsers); React Native later if a native app is wanted post-MVP.

- **Backend:** Node.js (NestJS/Express) or Python (Django/FastAPI) exposing a REST or GraphQL API; either is fine — pick whichever your team already knows.
- **Database:** PostgreSQL for core relational data (users, bookings, bids, ratings); PostGIS extension for location/map queries; Redis for caching and session/notification queues.
- **Maps:** Mapbox or Google Maps Platform for the interactive map, geocoding, and route/drive-time estimates.
- **Payments/escrow:** Stripe Connect (supports marketplace-style split payments and delayed payout, which maps well to the escrow model) or a local PSP (PayHere) layered in for LKR-denominated payments if needed.
- **Messaging/notifications:** WebSocket-based in-app chat (e.g., Socket.IO) plus email/SMS/WhatsApp notifications for bid alerts and booking confirmations.
- **File storage:** S3-compatible storage for verification documents and photos, with signed URLs and admin-only access to sensitive docs.
- **Admin/verification tooling:** a separate internal admin panel (could start as a simple internal dashboard) for reviewing registrations, disputes, and content moderation.
- **Hosting:** any major cloud (AWS/GCP/Azure) or a simpler PaaS (Render, Railway, Vercel + a managed Postgres) for MVP to keep ops overhead low before scale is proven.

10. Core data model (entities)

Entity	Key fields	Notes
User	id, role (traveler/guide/company/admin), name, email, phone, currency, language	Base identity for all roles
GuideProfile / CompanyProfile	verification status, documents, languages, specialties, service areas, rating avg	1:1 with a User in guide/company role
Location	name, category, coordinates, description, fees, hours, media	Curated + community-enriched
Trip	traveler_id, dates, stops (Location refs), group size, budget range, status	The plan a traveler builds
Bid	trip_id, provider_id, price, inclusions, message, status (pending/accepted/rejected/expired)	One per provider per trip

Entity	Key fields	Notes
Booking	trip_id, accepted_bid_id or self_booked flag, payment_status, escrow_status	Created on bid acceptance or self-checkout
TransportBooking	type (vehicle/train/bus), leg details, provider/operator, price, ticket ref	For self-planned bookings, can attach to a Booking
Review	booking_id, rater_id, ratee_id, scores, text, visibility	Locked to completed bookings only
Payment	booking_id, amount, commission, payout_status	Ties to the payment processor's records
Message	conversation_id, booking_or_trip_id, sender_id, body, sent_at, read_at	Backs in-app messaging; timestamps drive the response-time trust signal
Notification	user_id, type, payload, channel (push/email/sms), sent_at, read_at	Bid alerts, verification results, dispute updates
AuditLog	actor_admin_id, action, target_type, target_id, timestamp, notes	Records every verification approval/rejection and dispute resolution
Dispute	booking_id, raised_by, reason, status, resolution	Admin-mediated

This is intentionally high-level — a real schema would add join tables for many-to-many relations (e.g., Trip–Location, Company–Guide staff), normalize currency/locale fields, and add a VerificationStatus enum on GuideProfile/CompanyProfile (pending / approved / rejected / resubmitted) so the verification queue and AuditLog above have something concrete to reference.

11. Phased roadmap

Phase 1 — Core planning + directory (no marketplace yet). Map, location pages, budget planner, transportation info (informational only). Basic traveler accounts. Read-only guide/company directory with manual admin-entered profiles to seed supply before self-

registration opens. Goal: prove the planning tool is useful enough that people want to come back.

Phase 2 — Marketplace MVP. Guide/company self-registration + admin verification queue. Trip posting, bidding, in-app messaging, bid selection, and payment/escrow for guided trips. Mutual-blind rating system. Goal: prove guides will bid and travelers will book through the platform instead of going around it.

Phase 3 — Self-planned booking. Vehicle rental booking, train/bus timetable integration, and (where feasible) in-app ticketing/seat booking; combined-itinerary checkout. Goal: capture the segment of travelers who never wanted a guide, and add a second revenue line.

Phase 4+ — Growth features. Featured listings/promotion, themed itineraries, multi-language support, group/split-cost trips, referral program, analytics dashboard for providers, and any of the additional suggestions from section 8 validated by early usage data.

Sequencing this way means the two riskiest, most build-heavy pieces — the bidding marketplace and real-time transport booking — aren't both due before you've learned anything from real users.

12. Risks & fixes needed before build

A self-review of this plan, grouped by how much damage each gap would do if left unresolved.

Legal & liability — resolve first, touches money and safety

- No stated answer for who's liable if a guide-led tour results in injury, a no-show, or a stranded traveler. Needs a written liability/insurance stance before guides start taking paying customers.
- "Verification" as scoped just checks that documents exist; it doesn't say the platform will validate an SLTDA guide license against the actual registry, or confirm business registration/insurance for companies. Decide the real verification method and who performs it (dedicated ops person vs. founders initially — this is recurring manual work, not a one-time setup).
- No cancellation/refund policy defined anywhere, even though the dispute flow assumes admins will apply one. Needs explicit rules (e.g., refund tiers by notice period, no-show handling) before escrow goes live.

- Tour operator licensing, platform business registration, and consumer-protection/refund obligations should be checked with a local lawyer before commissions and escrow launch.

Financial mechanics

- Escrow release now has a concrete state machine (see section 7), but confirm the hold window and dispute-trigger cutoff with whoever handles support before building it.
- FX exposure isn't addressed: confirm what currency the traveler is charged in vs. what the guide/company is paid in, and who absorbs the movement between those two events.
- Confirm Stripe Connect (or chosen PSP) actually supports payouts to Sri Lankan bank accounts and smooth foreign-card acceptance — cross-border payment friction is a common failure point for this kind of marketplace.

Data model — Message, Notification, AuditLog, and a VerificationStatus enum have been added to section 10; still worth normalizing currency/locale fields and adding the Trip-Location and Company-Guide join tables when a real schema is cut.

Operational load

- Verification review, dispute mediation, and keeping the budget planner's fee/price data current are ongoing work, not launch tasks — size them as an ops headcount need.
- Add a formal pilot phase: onboard roughly 20–50 guides/companies in one region and run the marketplace semi-manually before opening bidding platform-wide, rather than jumping straight from Phase 1 to a fully public Phase 2.
- Fraud/trust risk not yet addressed: sybil accounts, fake bids, or incentivized reviews need at least a basic detection pass (e.g., reviews locked to completed paid bookings, as already planned, plus rate limits on new accounts).

Smaller technical gaps

- Tech stack (section 9) doesn't mention error tracking or product analytics (e.g., Sentry + PostHog/Amplitude) — add before launch, not after the first incident.
- Verification documents (ID, passport, business registration) need encryption at rest and admin-only access, not just "S3-compatible storage."

Still open from the original scoping

- Train/bus data access: does Sri Lanka Railways or private bus operators expose a booking API, or does this need scraping/partnership? Materially affects Phase 3 timeline, and now also affects whether commission can apply there at all (see section

7).

- Hotel/accommodation booking — in or out of scope? A natural extension but its own supply/inventory problem.
- Native app vs. web-only for launch — web-responsive stays the cheaper starting point, native can follow later.

Next step: resolve the legal/liability and escrow-mechanics items above first — they touch real money and real safety before anything can be walked back. Everything else here can be built in parallel or adjusted once the platform has real users.

13. UI/UX: modern, mobile-first, interactive

This is a mobile-heavy product (tourists planning and checking things on the go), so the interface should be designed mobile-first, not shrunk down from a desktop layout afterward.

Look & feel. Clean, photo-forward design (Sri Lanka's scenery is a selling point — use real imagery, not stock icons, on location and provider cards); card-based layouts for locations, guides, and bids so they scan well on a small screen; light and dark mode; a small, consistent design system (spacing, type scale, one accent color) rather than a different style per screen. Tools like Tailwind CSS with a component library (shadcn/ui or similar) get a modern look quickly without reinventing components.

Mobile-friendly by construction. Fully responsive web app that works as well in a phone browser as on desktop, with large tap targets, bottom navigation on mobile (map, trips, messages, profile), and a Progressive Web App (PWA) setup so travelers can "add to home screen" and get offline access to a saved itinerary without needing an app-store install.

Interactivity. The map is the centerpiece: drag-and-drop to reorder stops, tap a marker for a quick-preview card, pinch/zoom smoothly, and animate the route line as stops are added or removed. The budget planner updates totals live as sliders move, with a small chart showing the cost breakdown. Bidding screens update in real time (new bid arrives without a page refresh) using WebSockets, with a subtle notification/badge rather than an intrusive alert. Skeleton loading states and light micro-interactions (button feedback, saved-trip confirmation) make the app feel responsive rather than static.

Onboarding & flow. A short, visual onboarding (pick interests, trip length, rough budget) that feeds straight into personalized location suggestions, rather than a blank map on first use. Progress indicators on multi-step flows (planning → posting a trip → comparing bids →

booking) so travelers always know where they are.

Accessibility. Sufficient color contrast, readable type sizes, and screen-reader-friendly markup from the start — cheap to build in early, expensive to retrofit, and it also helps older or less tech-savvy travelers use the app comfortably.